

SANTA FE, NEW MEXICO USA



Fiery Chili Peppers in Santa Fe

In the soft, clear light of a Santa Fe morning, Native American artisans spread their jewelry-laden blankets before the Palace of the Governors, built by Spanish settlers 400 years ago, while Anglo-American tourists stroll in the plaza below. This mix of cultures has given the city some wondrous arts and architecture, and a cuisine that calls on over 100 varieties of chili pepper.



Set high against the backdrop of the Sangre de Cristo mountains, Santa Fe is the capital of New Mexico, the oldest

state capital in North America, established when Spanish conquistadors from Mexico founded a colony here in 1610. Its mix of cultural history and contemporary Southwestern style offers plenty for everyone to explore. At its heart lies the Plaza, lined on three sides by storefronts – a shopper's delight for Southwestern clothes, jewelry, arts, and crafts. The surrounding streets are as likely to lead to the earthy curves of old adobe houses as they are to hotels and public buildings sporting Spanish Colonial or Pueblo Revival styles, their soft pink and beige facades gleaming against a brilliant blue sky.

Old mission churches, sanctuaries, and a magnificent cathedral evoke the city's colonial roots. There are excellent museums highlighting Native American traditions, culture, and contemporary arts, and a wealth of fine art galleries and museums. Artists have long come to northern New Mexico for

its clear light and spectacular hues. But in the restaurants of Santa Fe, only two colors matter: red and green, the colors of piquant chili peppers.

The local foods of the Native Americans have always used corn, beans, and above all, chili peppers, and these form the basis of the cuisine of New Mexico. It's the hot peppers that set these dishes apart from Mexican cuisine found elsewhere in the US. Instead of the standard tomato-based salsas, here you'll find fresh sauces of puréed green or ground dried red chili peppers, lightly seasoned with garlic, salt, or herbs to let the smoky, pungent flavors of the peppers shine through. Great with burritos or enchiladas; try both the red and green salsas by asking for "Christmas."

As well as forming the base for the zesty sauces of burritos, enchiladas, and meat entrées, peppers are used in mouthwatering dishes such as crispy deep-fried *chiles rellenos* (stuffed peppers) and *carne adovada* (marinated pork). Other exotic local ingredients, such as blue corn, *nopales* (prickly pear cactus), and *chayote* (vegetable pear), also tickle the taste buds; Southwestern cuisine offers plenty for everyone to explore.

The Best Places to Eat New Mexico Cuisine

The Shed moderate

Some of the best New Mexico cuisine in Santa Fe comes with loads of atmosphere at The Shed. Just east of the Plaza, a wooden gateway leads to a sunny, flower-filled patio and the old adobe hacienda, which dates from 1692. Its nine cozy, adjoining rooms are charmingly decorated with folk art, its niches and doorways are brightly painted, and there is alfresco dining on the patio in summer.

Family-owned for three generations, The Shed's menu features time-tested recipes such as the smoky-flavored green chili pepper chicken enchiladas, and red chili pepper enchiladas topped with a fried egg, a local favorite. All of The Shed's chili peppers are grown to order on local farms and ground daily in their own mill, making the food some of the freshest and tastiest around. It's also very spicy. Traditional entrées are served with blue corn tortillas, and may be accompanied by *posole* (a hominy stew), *calabacitas* (a squash dish), and pinto beans. Reservations are advised for dinner. The always-busy lunchtime operates on a first-come, first-served basis.

113½ East Palace Avenue, Santa Fe;
open 11 AM–2:30 PM & 5:30–9 PM Mon–Sat;
www.sfshed.com

Also in Santa Fe

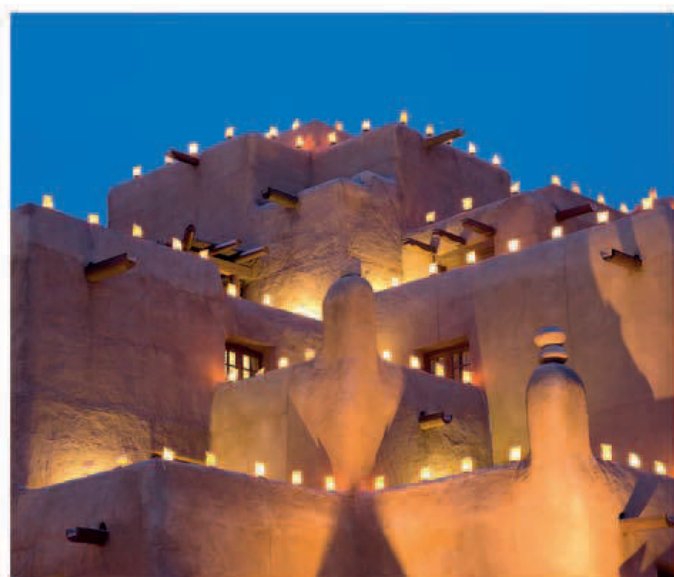
Several Santa Fe restaurants deserve a place on the "must try" list. **La Choza (505 982 0909; inexpensive)**, The Shed's little sister, near Railyard Park, is less busy but serves the same great food. **Maria's New Mexican Kitchen (www.marias-santafe.com; moderate)** is famous for its margaritas, but the menu is fantastic too; *carne adovada* (marinated pork) is a specialty. **Tomasita's (505 983 5721; moderate)** is another local favorite, with delicious *chiles rellenos*.

Also in New Mexico

New Mexican food tends to be low to moderately priced, though dishes often feature in pricier Southwestern restaurants such as **Doc Martin's** in the historic **Taos Inn (www.taosinn.com; expensive)**, Taos. **Orlando's New Mexican Cafe (http://orlandostaos.com; inexpensive)**, also in Taos, serves superb dishes in hearty portions. In Albuquerque, head for the **Church Street Cafe (www.churchstreetcafe.com; moderate)** in the Old Town.

Around the World

It's hard to find authentic New Mexican cuisine outside the state of New Mexico, but **Little Anita's (www.littleanitas.com; moderate)** has several locations in Denver, CO. In Seattle, head for **Santa Fe Cafe (www.santafecafeseattle.com; moderate)** for blue corn tacos and chili peppers sourced from Hatch, New Mexico.



Above Luminarias light up the 300-year-old adobe buildings in Santa Fe

Cooking Classes

Whether you want to roast a chili pepper or stuff one for a *chile relleno*, the **Santa Fe School of Cooking (www.santafeschoolofcooking.com)** is the best place to learn the secrets of New Mexican cuisine. Courses at this internationally renowned culinary academy are taught by some of the city's best chefs, but are geared toward recreational cooks as well as budding professionals. Courses range from morning or afternoon classes on a single topic or dish to the three-day **Southwest Culinary Boot Camp**, which covers everything from the history of the region's foods to in-depth cooking techniques. Demonstration and hands-on classes are offered. There are also classes on New Mexican cheeses and wines, as well as restaurant walking tours. Participants can stock up on regional ingredients at the adjoining market.